The Syndrome of Silence

Contents

In Front of the Door 2
Encore Lesson 2
Upbeat of Humanity 4
Misinterpretation 5
Self-Transcendence 7

In Front of the Door

COL-603200

The subtle fragrance of nectar works its way into your dream and wakes you from your sleep.

Even with your eyes shut, you can tell this isn't the room you usually stay in.

Choices

1. Open your eyes.

2. Try to go back to sleep.

3. Stretch your body.

Branch 1

Still, no matter where you look, the space is colored Klein Blue—just like everywhere else.

Branch 2

You try to sink back into the comfort of darkness, but the sweet scent stimulates your senses.

In the end, you're forced awake in a room drenched in Klein Blue.

Branch 3

You roll and turn as you stretch off the stiffness of a long rest, exploring the space as you do so.

It feels meaninglessly empty. You could roll around a few more times without hitting a thing.

Shared continuation

A note hangs prominently on the door, its stark lettering immediately readable at a glance:

On the other side of this door is your homeland, though one you've never seen before.
You may go around as you like until I return.
Remember to say hello at the Paris base. Try to be polite.
Don't mention Manus Vindictae to strangers.

Have a pleasant trip, and stay safe.

Encore Lesson

COL-603201

The ritual has ended. Beneath the Arc de Triomphe, only two figures are left standing among several headless bodies scattered across the ground. A female figure approaches them.

Ustrina: How fared the ritual? Where are the members of the Headless Society?

Ustrina: The "Storm" approaches. I am here to bring you back to shelter.

Taira: They're dead.

Ustrina: Seeking life through death is folly, like breaking a clay lamp for its wick.

Ustrina: I do not understand their reasoning, but I do wonder what sort of wick they were hoping to find.

Taira: Stop wondering. The wick is gone. They're dead, nothing more. The ritual failed.

Ustrina: Did you not cut off their heads as required?

Taira: Not me. They chose Coppélia as the executor—claimed she was more suitable.

Taira: But it seems Coppélia didn't meet their requirements either. They said so with their final breath.

Big Hat: *cough* A pity ... It seems you didn't meet the requirements in the end.

Coppélia: ㄚ... I ... did something wrong?

Big Hat: Oh ... don't be upset. Any head still attached to a neck is enslaved to thought.

Big Hat: Whether it was a vulgar emotion or a grounding idea that got in your way, it doesn't matter much—it simply kept you from being perfectly useless, that's all.

Big Hat: Or perhaps it was me who couldn't fully let go of human wisdom. This ritual ... haha ... it's just ridiculous! Hahahaha!

Coppélia: ㄧ-Your head is ... glowing ...?

Big Hat: Beautiful, isn't it? Like the shining sun!

Big Hat: But it'll soon go out. I'll take my freedom the simple way now.

Big Hat: I wouldn't recommend it though—quite tedious, really. You'd better find another way.

Coppélia: ㄨ-What can I do?

Big Hat: Oh, you're already a wonderful person. Now you get to feel for yourself, think for yourself, and struggle through the pain ahead.

Taira: Then the flames on their necks flickered out. I'm almost certain they're gone for good.

Ustrina: Hm. A banal end. Bring Coppélia. We're leaving.

Coppélia: *sob*

Taira: Coppélia, do you hear me? Coppélia?!

Coppélia hears Taira's voice, but she can't tear her eyes away from the Big Hats lying motionless on the ground. Maybe the ritual didn't fail completely.

She senses something—an invisible force awakened by their deaths.

It squeezes her heart, choking her throat, even making the moisture in the air sting her eyes.

Coppélia: *wail*

Then these things called grief and guilt make her legs give out. She collapses to the ground, crying uncontrollably.

Ustrina: What is this? What's wrong with her?

Taira: I have no idea. Coppélia, listen to me.

Coppélia: ㄥ ... My eyes sting, nose burns, throat ... on fire ...

Ustrina: How odd. Is this your doing?

Taira: Me? She was only following orders.

Ustrina: Tears come with sadness, Taira. It's a rudimentary emotion.

Taira: What could she be sad over?

Ustrina: Why do you ask me? I deal with the dead, or those knocking at its door. Their sadness is simple, but this? This is beyond my understanding.

Ustrina: My work lies in the stilling of souls, not the drying of tears. This is yours to deal with.

Taira: Uh ... Listen, Coppélia, this failure doesn't fall upon your shoulders. The Headless Society refused to join us, but you did as we asked. No punishment awaits you.

Taira: Their ritual was foolish, and they paid the price for it ...

Coppélia: ㄅ-But the Big Hats ... I don't hear them anymore. They're gone. ㄙ-Said they would get back up, but didn't.

Realizing her newly made friends have turned into silent, lifeless objects, Coppélia's crying threatens to drown out the thumping rain.

Meanwhile, her temporary guardians still don't understand what's wrong.

Ustrina: You spoke wrongly.

Taira: How, exactly?

Ustrina: I don't know, but she's crying harder. Perhaps it was your tone.

Ustrina: The "Storm" is nearly upon us. Get her up. Now.

Taira: Then lend me a hand! I'm hardly adept at dealing with crying children!

Ustrina: She is seventeen, Taira. Hardly a child.

Ustrina: And I don't know how to deal with her either. As I said, this is not my domain.

Taira: Why couldn't it have been Lyra or ... ah, no matter.

Taira: At least help me carry her back.

Upbeat of Humanity

COL-603202

Coppélia sinks Taira's blade deep into his chest. His human body crumples to the ground, while the crab on his face continues to twitch. The Big Hats, who have been silently watching, begin to clap.

Big Hat: Well done! You have claimed your autonomy, wresting free from your rulers.

Big Hat: A shame though, that you're now trapped in a cage of thoughts, tied down by a taboo called a conscience. You've lost sovereignty over the universe.

Big Hat: Looks like you're no longer fit to be our ritual's executor. So, what will you do now?

Coppélia: ㄚ-I don't know ...

Big Hat: A brilliant answer!

The big hat, still hiding whatever's beneath, adjusts its brim, putting away its dramatic gestures.

Big Hat: I mourn the beast that once ruled over humanity, and I honor the tool that has become human again.

Big Hat: No ritual today. No use sticking around.

Big Hat: I'm off to the carnival at Champ de Mars. People there are rejecting their work and returning to their animalistic nature—mustn't miss that.

Coppélia: Can I come too ...?

Big Hat: No, you can't. You've only just become human. No reason to go back to being a clueless animal.

Big Hat: What you need now is to wrestle with your thoughts, feel the pain of it all, and then dream up a future right in the middle of it.

Big Hat: I believe this might be the last time we ever meet, so farewell!

The Big Hat finally lifts its hat, giving a proper tip of it, but through the heavy rain Coppélia can't make out a face.

This downpour seems intent on washing away every melody in the city.

Coppélia reaches out, feeling the raindrops fall from above. She knows there's nothing scary about this kind of rain, but that soon, it will reverse its direction.

Normally, she'd run to her comrades for shelter, but she knows they wouldn't agree with what she did today. She can no longer stay with those who have no conscience.

She must find her own place to hide.

Coppélia: ㄨ-What ... What should I do now ...?

She hears the crab moving behind her but keeps her eyes focused on the road ahead.

Coppélia: Huh?

Then, she catches the faint scent of nectar in the wet air, the same one from when she first awoke.

???: Come. The rain is about to start.

Coppélia: But ㄚ-I can't go back ... I ㄉㄧˋㄙ—disobeyed a lord ...

Coppélia: I don't know. ㄏㄚˊ-Have I done wrong?

The flowers on the woman's body playfully blink at Coppélia. She glances with moist eyes at the crab scuttling away in the distance.

???: You'll have plenty of time to wonder whether your choice was right or wrong.

???: For now, just remember—there is always more than one place to shelter from the rain.

???: Come with me. This time, we'll not return to that meaningless blue room.

Misinterpretation

COL-603701

By the time Coppélia breaks free from Ustrina's control, the ritual is already over.

She staggers over to a Big Hat lying on the ground.

Coppélia: ㄚ ... ㄚ-I came for the ritual too. Am I late?

No reply comes from beneath the hat. The light his head emits is fading.

Then, she hears some questions, clear as the pitter-patter of raindrops.

Ustrina: You would go so far as to fight us, just to save them?

Ustrina: Is it because they made you a promise? Offered you something of a value even you can understand?

Ustrina: Or is it because the ritual failed, and you're angry you won't receive payment? Money does have a tendency to make even peaceful people turn violent. Is it the same for you?

Taira: What are you going on about?

Ustrina: I am simply wondering what drives her. She wouldn't be the first to lay down her life for wealth, nor would she be the last.

The two voices sound so close and yet so distant. Coppélia doesn't understand the words, but her hands, still clutching the hat's brim, can't help but tremble.

Coppélia: ㄨ-What else can I do? Could you tell me?

Ustrina: Hmm. From the sounds of it, my assumption was wrong. I suppose it's to be expected—reading the living has never been my forte. But I digress.

Ustrina: All we can ascertain is that she wishes to complete a ritual that would, in essence, bring about her own death, no?

Though the rain pours down on them, it doesn't put out the flame in Ustrina's chest. If anything, it feeds it.

A sense of unease stirs in Taira's pincers. He shakes the raindrops from them only for even more to take their place.

Taira: Never mind what she's thinking. We're done here—help me carry her back. Since when do you have so much to say, anyway?

Her flame, unfazed by Taira's words, dances as she crouches and grips Coppélia's shoulders, forcing her to face its cold glow.

Ustrina: It was their promise of death that fed your emotions, wasn't it, Coppélia?

Coppélia: Coppélia stares into the flame. Her stiff fingers drag the hat from the dim head.

Ustrina: No answer? It matters not. I have another method of verifying this conclusion.

Ustrina: If you wish to shed this mortal coil, then come—let us take part in an even greater ritual.

Taira: You're ...! Have you, too, lost your mind?!

The patterns on Taira's shell writhe with indignation. He turns and storms away.

The Seine looks nothing like it did just a few hours prior. Now, people march along its banks, their strange festivities melting into and blurring with the pouring rain.

The ferryboat rocks against the ripples created by their passion.

Ustrina, standing at its bow, breaks the silence.

Ustrina: You see, they're always like this, cheering slogans for tomorrow, raging over today's wages. First, they build their own cages; then, from within those bars, they seek the key.

Ustrina: They pile endless kindling beneath their own feet to fuel their shifting emotions, until at last they bury themselves in the pyre's flames and call it liberation of the soul.

Ustrina: A scene I've witnessed countless times, ever since I was but a lamp. A scene I've grown so accustomed to.

Ustrina: But your feelings are different. They're pure—still tender and new. For a novice like me, that makes them far easier to learn from and understand.

Coppélia stares at the water. She's never heard Ustrina speak this much, and stranger still, she's neither questioning nor scolding her.

Coppélia: ㄚ-I ... I don't know. The Big Hats were kind. They said that I could do it. ㄚ-I need to—

Ustrina's flame lights up the surrounding river, making Coppélia feel as though she's riding atop a drifting lantern.

Coppélia: ㄉ-Death is ... transcending order. It is an experience, an enlightenment, for our sovereignty ...

Ustrina: Haha. You actually believe that drivel of theirs.

Ustrina: Oh? That sound I just made is what they called "laughter," is it not? An expression of happiness or amusement, I believe. Yes ... Say more—I can feel something new stirring. I was right to bring you along.

Coppélia: ㄧㄝ-Yes. Death is ... the right decision. A fearless death is the finest ...

The rain intensifies, drowning out the voices on the shore. Coppélia tightens her grip on the hat. She sees the flame's azure glow at the corner of her eye, yet its owner's voice seems much further away.

Ustrina: Hmm. I find I no longer care about my unanswered questions. That, too, is a new sensation. And yet, the moment I stopped caring, the answer revealed itself to me.

Ustrina: Lamp oil and kindling were never the key to burning bright, nor were they the key to feeling. The key is rain—for every flame yearns for a deluge to snuff it out.

Ustrina: And this is a proper downpour. Just look at you—drenched to the bone.

Coppélia: ᛉ-I will ... be snuffed out too?

Rainwater streaks down her face. She looks back down at the hat, still held tight in her stiff, wet hands. It feels like a dark cloud now, its tears spilling upward.

Bittersweet: Before the "Storm" arrived, I told Ustrina to bring Coppélia back with her. But in the end ... *sigh* Even Taira could offer no explanation on his return.

Hummingbird: You have my condolences. If it's any consolation, I believe she will soon traverse death and find you once more.

Bittersweet: Sweet child. The sorrow trailing your words tells me this faint wish is heartfelt. I take it your research has seen some progress?

Hummingbird: Yes. Professor Roseau's work—his study of the Depths of Myth is what brought me to Paris.

Bittersweet: Ah, the trove of the subconscious. A most fascinating place. But it isn't made up of humans' and arcanists' myths alone. Entities ancient and mysterious make their home there, too.

Bittersweet: Don't rush in before you've fully mastered the revival ritual. What awaits you there is far more beautiful—and far more dangerous—than an inverted Paris.

Bittersweet: Ah, forgive my presumptuousness. My words are nothing more than the ramblings of a florist who has just lost her precious seedling, loath to see others disappear for nothing.

Hummingbird: No need to apologize; I'll bear your warning in mind. Still, I can't help but wonder—how much do you know about this treasure trove?

Bittersweet: A decent amount. An old friend often visits me in dreams to talk about it. I can introduce you if you'd like.

Hummingbird: I appreciate your generosity. Would you care to walk with me along the river? The evening is still young. We have plenty of time to talk.

Self-Transcendence

COL-603702

With a deafening rumble, the giant creature falls. It lies there motionless, save for the twitching metal pipes on its body.

Voices from behind the door reach Coppélia before she can catch her breath. Fortunately, the concert hall offers plenty of places to hide.

Lyra: What a mess! Still hiding, Coppélia? First you're angry, and now you're frightened?

Lyra: I didn't take you for this much of a fool. Don't tell me you're going to make me come find you myself.

Bittersweet: Such panic. If I didn't know better, I'd assume they'd all found their own "Félicienne." What happened here?

The familiar scent of nectar eases Coppélia's nerves. Even so, she tries to follow the conversation outside rather than show herself.

Lyra: Right on cue. Every time that little tuning fork steps out of line, there you are. Come to pour out that bottomless conscience of yours again? Don't tell me you've actually developed a taste for playing nanny.

Bittersweet: Manus Vindictae treats all arcanist children as equals. I can only hope you haven't forgotten that.

Lyra: Yet arcane talent itself is not equally shared.

Lyra: Take this organ, for instance. I channeled the full force of my orchestra into creating it, nurturing it, tuning it, and for what? So it can make some wretch's meager abilities just the least bit useful?

Lyra: I devoted no less of myself to its creation than you've devoted to any of your little "seedlings." And that devotion saw it become more than a mere node in the "Windweave." It turned it into a chorus of countless talents, saw it nearly reach the boundaries of beauty!

Lyra: And Coppélia has what it takes to understand it. Such talent should be handled with care.

Bittersweet: Of course, you've always seen Coppélia as a fine instrument. She has trembled through every performance, always done precisely what you ordered, no more and no less.

Lyra: Such are the results of my constant tuning and correction. Alas, she must be disciplined this time. Only then will she know where the boundaries lie.

The conversation stops, and footsteps follow. Coppélia squeezes her eyes shut and shrinks further into the corner.

But the efforts do nothing to drive the footsteps away.

The warning signs of capture—a piercing "wind" that scatters like a barrage of arrows—arrive before anything else.

Coppélia remembers the vibrations and how they reverberate through her. She remembers how Lyra, even with her back turned, could catch her every move, every beat, every breath ...

The "wind" tells Lyra everything.

It swirls around Coppélia like the opening notes of every tuning session ... Yet this time, it carries a faint fragrance.

Coppélia: ...

Lyra: I'm honing your talent—you merely lack the means to understand! You know not the refinement a perfect instrument must endure!

Lyra: So quit your hiding! Pour your anger and fear into the music, Coppélia!

The scolding has the dazed Coppélia hugging herself tighter, eyes still squeezed shut. Soon, the footsteps fade away, and she finds herself still tucked safely in her corner.

There's the sound of a door shutting, then another set of footsteps, and finally, a hand settling on her shoulder.

Bittersweet: It's a good thing you always carry that nectar on you. It's how I found you so quickly.

Coppélia breathes in the calming fragrance. A pleasant haziness washes over her, but before she can indulge further, the woman disperses its traces and looks at her with gentle eyes.

Bittersweet: But don't let the scent go to your head. It isn't meant for you.

Bittersweet: Come along. A budding seedling shouldn't linger in the dark. Step into the sunlight—so much more awaits you out there.

Coppélia: ⅄ -Where ... are we going?

Bittersweet: Think of it as a greenhouse, somewhere safe for you to grow, somewhere Lyra won't find you.

Coppélia: A house ... Safety?

Bittersweet: Yes. There are teachers there to guide you as you bloom, similar to the ones guiding the melody here, as well as companions. But unlike here, you will be free.

Coppélia: Free? ... Free! I remember ... "Freedom is ours! Time off and benefits!"

Coppélia tries to swing her arms to the beat of the chant, but she's stopped by Bittersweet's hands on her own.

Bittersweet: Shh, don't let the wind hear you. We leave now. The further from the orchestra, the better—oh, you're not allergic to wax, are you?